



Firefox for mobiles

Codenamed "Fennec", it's under development. An alpha release is now available to download.

Safari

Mobile users will have used this if they coughed up the dough for an iPhone, or an iPod Touch, and they will be perhaps the most content of all us mobile net junkies. Safari is the best mobile browser yet — it is fast, renders impeccably, scrolls and zooms beautifully, and since it's found on Apple devices, the multi-touch really makes it simple for anyone to use. It's still got a long way to go though — it needs to add Flash support, fails the Acid3 test (74/100), and when pages break, they break terribly. Remember, WebKit claims to pass the Acid3 test with Safari 4.



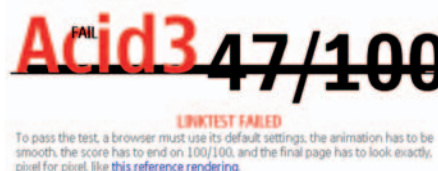
Opera Mobile

This is Opera's Windows mobile and Symbian browser, which is bundled in some devices, and available for download for all others. Opera have their own closed-source browser engine called Presto, and as you can see from the desktop version's results, the Acid3 results, although not perfect, seem to suggest that Presto certainly follows more web standards than the rest. Opera Mobile 9.5 beta scores 73/100 in Acid3, and the tests it fails are less likely to affect page layouts. A look at the screenshots should tell you what you need to know.



Nokia Symbian 60

Nokia's S60-based phones use a browser that's also based on WebKit, like Android and Safari, but somehow it doesn't do as well as its cousins. It scores 47/100 in the Acid3 test, and generally does not feel as fast and smooth (rendering) as its cousins. The one good feature it does add, which its cousins need to seriously think about, is Flash Lite support. There's still a lot of tweaking needed, and Flash-lite on our test phone (a Nokia E51) was buggy and slow because it ate a lot of resources — but at least it worked. There are some decent Flash Lite applications available, just make sure you don't use any of the screensavers — they just eat into your battery life. ■



Mobile Browsers



Flash Lite

Flash Lite is Adobe's way of bring Flash content to the mobile phone specifically, and mobile devices in general. The Lite part of its name should immediately tell you that this is not a full blown Flash player, like the version for desktop browsers or Adobe's Shockwave player, but it does have some interesting uses. You should check if your device is Flash Lite capable, and if it is, make sure to visit Adobe's Marketplace at <http://www.adobe.com/cfusion/exchange/>. Just search for Flash Lite, and you should find hundreds of apps that may interest you.

Internet Explorer

IE on Windows Mobile is a barely able to render anything properly. If you thought Acid3 tests scores for its desktop version were bad, you have no clue how bad, bad can be. With so many sites breaking, it doesn't make sense to even bother here. It's obvious that IE has a long way to go before it's suitable for smaller screens. For now, we'd rather urge Windows Mobile users to download Opera

Mobile, which may not run as well as it does on Symbian, but at least you'll be able to surf the net!

Opera Mini

The best part about Opera Mini is that it can be installed on almost any mobile device — whether the iPhone, any Symbian device or even the run of the mill, everyday (Java-enabled) mobile phone. Opera mini is specialised for small-screen browsing, and renders really well. Opera Mini scores 80/100 in the Acid3 test, which is commendable.



Mini uses Opera servers to compress, reformat and optimise data for your small screen, which results in faster page transfers, and little or no processing power required on your end. Unlike Opera Mobile, where your mobile does all the processing and page rendering, Mini lets a server farm somewhere in cyber space worry about all that, and just displays content on your screen. It's also a good application for those on a pay-per-use data plan, because, for all practical purposes, Mini zips (as in compression, and speed) the net for you, saving you precious bandwidth

and time. I for one am thankful for it, because I barely get 2 or 3 Kbps over my pathetic GPRS connection, but can still do everything I need to online, from anywhere, using Mini.

Now what?

As usual, there needs to be some logical conclusion to the whole thing, right? Wrong. We still have a long way to go before the "mobile web" is as accessible as the "desktop web". Recent news reports have suggested that the number of mobile users globally (and especially in India), are increasing exponentially. Much before we have one laptop per child we might end up having one mobile per child, and this is something that all mobile service providers are well aware of. The mobile is the new PC, and everyone and their uncles are hopping on to the mobile space to try something.

While this is great news for those of us who love the convenience of mobile connectivity, all we can do is hope that groups like the W3C and the WSP succeed in encouraging the use of standards, or else it might not be as much of a runaway success story as the desktop web is.

Still, with some mobile devices starting to match the processing power of a 6 year old PC, perhaps we're all going to be thrown into another race for performance, and will again skilfully adapt Moore's Law for the mobile space to justify constant upgrades and doubling of features on mobiles. Perhaps we're wasting time worrying about which browser to use, because in the near future we might be bickering over which OS to use and which antivirus software is best... whatever the outcome, we'll still be here to help point the way.

